7. After Confession

Do your penance. Complete it as soon as you can, ideally the same day. That is the third act of the penitent: satisfaction. A penance left undone is a gift left unopened.

Make it right where you can. If you stole, return it. If you lied about someone, correct it. If you have a quarrel, seek peace. Penance completes what absolution has begun, but justice still asks for the repair.

Give thanks. You walk out as you walked out of Baptism — clean. Stay a few minutes before the Blessed Sacrament.

```
Lord, I thank you for your mercy.
Help me to live in your grace and to avoid sin.
```

Come back. Confession is a habit, not a reset. Monthly confession, even of venial sins, is a common and fruitful practice. Do not wait for a great sin to return; the sacrament is medicine for the small ones too.

If you have been away for years. Say so at the start. Confess the grave sins you can sincerely remember; the Church does not ask for what you cannot recall. Do not receive Holy Communion in mortal sin before you have been — and if you are in danger of death and cannot reach a priest, make an act of perfect contrition and confess as soon as you can.

If a censure is involved. Abortion, apostasy, and a few other grave sins carry excommunication. That is no reason to stay away: confession is the very place the censure is lifted, and the priest will tell you what to do.

A Note on These Texts

- **What is dogma.** Penance is a sacrament instituted by Christ, in which the priest forgives sin in his person; the seal of confession is absolute (Council of Trent, Session XIV; CCC 1422–1498; canon 983).
- **What is discipline.** The rite, the words of absolution, the schedule, the screen or the chair, the age of first confession — all may change, and none binds under sin.
- **What is devotion.** The prayer before reconciliation is a traditional devotional composition, not part of the rite; the two Acts of Contrition are approved forms, and any sincere words of sorrow will do.
- **The fuller study.** For the doctrine, special cases, and Eastern Catholic practice, see The Order of Confession and Examination of Conscience.

The Order of Confession

A Simple Guide, Step by Step

1. The Five Movements

Confession — the Sacrament of Penance — is the ordinary way Christ forgives the sins committed after Baptism. Every confession has five movements:

1. **Examination of conscience** — prayerfully recall your sins.
2. **Contrition** — sorrow for them, and a firm purpose to amend.
3. **Confession** — telling them to the priest.
4. **Absolution** — God's forgiveness, given through the priest.
5. **Satisfaction** — doing the penance he gives you.

Before you go. Look up the parish confession times — website, bulletin, or the parish office. If no time is published, ask for an appointment; a priest will always make one for a penitent. Let the office know if you would like the screen or the room.

How long it takes. A short confession is a few minutes; a first confession, or one after a long absence, may take ten or fifteen. Nobody is timing you, and no one in the queue knows what you are confessing.

What to confess. Every grave sin, with its **kind** and its **number** (or approximate frequency). A sin is mortal when the matter is grave, you knew it, and you deliberately consented. Venial sins may be confessed too, and it is good to do so: frequent confession of small sins is a strong guard against great ones.

Bring the nuggets, keep the sauce. Be specific about what you did; leave out the long story. The priest needs the sin, not the plot.

Too vague	Too detailed	Just right
"I gossiped."	Who said what to whom, and how you came to hear	"I gossiped a few times about a friend."
"I wasn't good."	Every email, text, and word of a long quarrel	"I lost my temper at work and insulted a coworker."

Why a priest? Because Christ gave men the power to forgive: "Receive the Holy Spirit. Whose sins you shall forgive, they are forgiven them" (John 20:22–23). The priest acts in Christ's person, not in his own — so his own sanctity, or lack of it, does not touch the gift you receive.

What it is not. Not a courtroom where you must defend yourself; not a performance of holiness; not a place where the priest decides whether God is willing to forgive. He is bound to forgive the penitent who confesses and is sorry: that is what the keys are for. You will not be scolded, and you will not be told to come back when you are better — you come back because you are not.

6. Steps 7 to 9

Step 7 — pray the Act of Contrition. The traditional form:

```
O my God, I am heartily sorry for having offended Thee,
and I detest all my sins because of Thy just punishments,
but most of all because they offend Thee, my God,
who art all good and deserving of all my love.
I firmly resolve, with the help of Thy grace,
to sin no more and to avoid the near occasions of sin. Amen.
```

The modern form:

```
My God, I am sorry for my sins with all my heart.
In choosing to do wrong and failing to do good,
I have sinned against You whom I should love above all things.
I firmly intend, with Your help, to do penance,
to sin no more, and to avoid whatever leads me to sin.
Our Savior Jesus Christ suffered and died for us.
In His name, my God, have mercy. Amen.
```

If you have neither, say from the heart: **"Lord Jesus, Son of God, have mercy on me, a sinner."** If you cannot remember it at all, tell the priest and he will help you.

The firm purpose. Contrition carries a resolve, not a feeling: to avoid this sin, and the occasions that lead to it. Feelings come and go; the resolve is what you bring. Name one concrete thing you will do differently this week.

Step 8 — receive absolution. The priest extends his hand and prays:

```
God, the Father of mercies,
through the death and the resurrection of his Son,
has reconciled the world to himself
and sent the Holy Spirit among us for the forgiveness of sins;
through the ministry of the Church
may God give you pardon and peace,
and I absolve you from your sins
in the name of the Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy Spirit.
```

Answer: **Amen.** At that moment your sins are forgiven — the words are Christ's, spoken through his minister.

Step 9 — the dismissal.

- Priest: *"Give thanks to the Lord, for he is good."*
- You: *"For his mercy endures forever."*
- Priest: *"The Lord has freed you from your sins. Go in peace."*
- You: *"Thanks be to God."*

A shorter form — *"Go in peace, and pray for me"* — is answered the same way.

5. Steps 4 to 6

Step 4 — confess your sins. Name the kind of sin and, for grave sins, the number of times. An approximation is enough; if you truly do not know, say so. Be honest, clear, and short. For example:

```
I missed Mass on Sundays about ten times.
I have used pornography regularly for several years.
I have had sex outside of marriage with my partner.
I have stolen from my employer.
I have been drunk several times.
I have not been to confession for twelve years.
```

If you forget a mortal sin, the confession is still valid; mention it at your next confession. If you are ashamed, remember the seal — everything you say stays between you, the priest, and God.

Step 5 — conclude. When you have finished, say:

```
I am sorry for these and all my sins, Father.
```

That tells him you have finished, and he will move on to counsel and absolution.

Step 6 — receive counsel and penance. He may offer a word of advice or encouragement — take it as meant. Then he gives you a penance: usually some prayers, sometimes an act of charity to perform afterwards. Remember what he says; if you forget, ask him to repeat it, or ask him to write it down. If the penance seems heavy for a first confession, say so; he can lighten it.

The penance is not a price. It is a small share in the satisfaction of Christ, given so that the medicine may reach the wound. It does not buy the pardon; the pardon is already given. Do it gladly, and do it soon.

Say what it was, not what caused it. "I was unfaithful to my wife" is enough; the history of the marriage belongs in another conversation. If anxiety drives you to confess the same sins every time, tell the priest; his counsel in that case should be followed. He will not be scandalised by either the sin or the scruple.

Name the sin plainly. Do not dress it in euphemism and do not dress it up with excuses; the sacrament works on the truth. If the number escapes you, "about" or "many times" will serve, and a sin you honestly forget is not held against you.

Other matters. You may briefly raise something that is not a sin — a civil marriage to be convalidated, enrollment in the Brown Scapular, a question of doctrine. Arrange the details with him after confession, outside the seal: what he learns inside it, he can never act on. Keep it to a sentence here, and let the conversation wait until you are both outside; brevity is not rudeness, it protects the sacrament.

2. Examine Your Conscience

Ask the Holy Spirit for light, then go through the Ten Commandments and the precepts of the Church. Write your sins down if that helps you be honest.

- **1st** — Have I put anything above God: money, work, pleasure, another person? Neglected prayer? Used superstition, charms, horoscopes, or the rites of another religion?
- **2nd** — Used God's name carelessly or in anger? Sworn falsely? Broken a vow or a promise made to God?
- **3rd** — Missed Mass on Sunday or a holy day without a serious reason? Done needless work that kept me from worship? Come late or left early without cause?
- **4th** — Disobedient or disrespectful to my parents? Neglected my duties as a parent, spouse, or child? Failed to care for those in my charge?
- **5th** — Harmed anyone in body or spirit? Held hatred, or refused to forgive? Aborted a child, or helped in one? Abused drink or drugs? Recklessly endangered my own life or another's?
- **6th and 9th** — Sexual acts outside marriage: fornication, adultery, pornography, masturbation? Deliberately entertained lustful thoughts? Led another into sin?
- **7th and 10th** — Stolen, cheated, or kept what was not mine? Been envious, greedy, or wasteful? Failed to give to the poor what I could?
- **8th** — Lied, gossiped, or ruined someone's name? Betrayed a confidence? Failed to defend the innocent?
- **Precepts** — Confessed grave sin at least once a year? Received Communion in mortal sin? Broken the days of fasting and abstinence? Helped support the Church as I am able?

The seven capital sins are a second mirror: pride, avarice, envy, anger, lust, gluttony, sloth. Ask which of them rules your days; the commandments will name the acts, the capital sins will name the root. A third mirror is the duties of your own state in life — your work, your family, the promises you have made.

Focus on grave sins. Those are the ones to name and number. Do not rake over a childhood you cannot remember, and do not list every instance of a long habit — say what the habit is, and how long it has held you. The Church asks only for the sins you can sincerely recall.

Venial sins are still sin. Confessing them is not required, but the Church urges it: they wound charity even when they do not kill it, and they dispose us to the graver falls. The list above is a mirror, not a tablet of charges.

3. Before You Enter

This prayer is a traditional preparation, not part of the rite. Say it slowly, or use your own words.

```
O most merciful God! Prostrate at your feet, I implore your forgiveness.
I sincerely desire to leave all my evil ways
and to confess my sins with all sincerity to you and to your priest.
I am a sinner, have mercy on me, O Lord.
Give me a lively faith and a firm hope in the Passion of my Redeemer.
Give me, for your mercy's sake, a sorrow for having offended so good a
God.
Mary, my mother, refuge of sinners, pray for me
that I may make a good confession. Amen.
```

An act of sorrow, for when you have no card and no words.

```
Lord Jesus, Son of God, have mercy on me, a sinner.
```

Two kinds of sorrow. Imperfect contrition is sorrow for sin because it offends God and deserves punishment; it is enough for the sacrament. Perfect contrition is sorrow because sin offends God, who is all good; it forgives even before confession, but it includes the intention to confess. Ask for the better gift, and confess either way.

The seal of confession. The priest can never, for any reason, reveal what he hears — not directly, not by hint, not under pain of death (canon 983). What you say stays between you, the priest, and God. He is not there to judge you but to act in Christ's person. You will not shock him; he has heard worse, and he has absolved worse. The seal binds every priest, everywhere, for ever, and no sin of yours can loosen it.

Two ways to sit. Kneel behind a screen, unseen, or sit facing the priest. Both are lawful, and neither is better; choose the one that lets you speak freely. Even the face-to-face room usually has a screen you may ask for.

What if I feel nothing? Sorrow is an act of the will before it is a feeling. Dryness, distraction, and numbness are not sins and do not spoil the sacrament; bring the resolve, and ask for the feeling later. The saints confess the same dryness, and it is no obstacle.

Come early, and come plainly. Silence your phone, sit in a back pew, and pray. You need bring nothing but honesty — no preparation is required beyond a sincere examination.

You do not need the right words. A stammered confession is still a confession: the sacrament rests on your honesty and God's mercy, not on your fluency. And if you have never used a screen, it is simply a grille between two places to kneel; the priest cannot see you and does not wish to. Say what you have come to say, and let him carry the rest.

4. In the Confessional — Steps 1 to 3

Step 1 — find the confessional. Look for a line of people waiting, a booth built into the wall, or a small plainly furnished room. Some booths show a light: red means someone is inside and you wait; green, or no light, means it is free. If there is neither a line nor a light and the curtain is drawn, wait a moment — the priest may be finishing with another penitent — then knock softly.

Step 2 — take your place. Behind the screen, or in the chair. Many priests begin by making the Sign of the Cross; if he does not, make it yourself. You need not kneel; sit if that helps you speak.

Step 3 — the opening. If he is silent, he is waiting for you. Say:

```
Bless me, Father, for I have sinned.
It has been [length of time] since my last confession.
```

If it has been many years, or you do not remember ever making a proper confession, say so plainly. He has heard it before, and he will guide you from here:

```
Father, this is my first confession in a very long time.
Can you walk me through it?
```

What he will do. He may read a verse of Scripture, then he listens. He cannot see your face behind the screen and he is not taking notes. When you pause, he may ask a question to help you — answer it simply. Nothing you say can be repeated, so nothing you say can be used against you. If a question of faith is on your mind, ask it; he is glad to answer one.

Before you speak. Breathe. You are speaking to Christ, who already knows your sins and already wants to forgive them. A confession usually takes only a few minutes; there is no need to hurry and no need to be eloquent. Say it badly if you must; it will still be said.

If you lose your words, or begin to cry, simply say so. He will wait, and nothing is spoiled. If you bring a written list, you may read from it; you may leave it behind or take it away.

If two priests are hearing, either will do — take the shorter line. If the posted time has come and gone and the church is empty, ask at the sacristy; the priest is usually still near. If the priest speaks first, answer him simply: he may only be asking whether it has been a while.

Nerves are normal. Everyone is nervous the first time, and everyone who has stayed away for years is nervous coming back. The priest sees it constantly and thinks nothing of it; his only interest is that you get out of the confessional free. It is the one appointment in the world where the outcome is already settled in your favour.